

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	Hard

Question

Percentage Point Changes in US Federal Outlays Relative to GDP by Congressional Status

Period	Congressional status	Change in total outlays	Change in nondefense outlays	Change in defense outlays
1981–1988	divided	−0.4	−1.3	0.9
1975–1976	divided	2.7	3.0	−0.3
1977–1980	undivided	0.3	0.6	−0.3
1964–1968	undivided	1.9	1.4	0.5
1969–1974	divided	−1.8	2.1	−3.9

Economist Steve H. Hanke has shown that divided US Congresses—which occur when one party holds the majority in the House of Representatives and another holds the majority in the Senate—tend to accompany reductions in total federal outlays (spending) relative to gross domestic product (GDP), which Hanke interprets to reflect decreases in government size. Hanke calculated the percentage point change in total outlays (encompassing nondefense and defense outlays) for consecutive US Congresses. Hanke has pointed to his calculations as evidence that a divided Congress may be a “necessary but not sufficient condition” for a decrease in government size to occur.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the underlined claim?

Answer

- A. The periods of undivided Congresses were associated with increases in nondefense outlays, whereas all the periods of divided Congresses except one were associated with reductions in defense outlays.
- B. All the periods of divided Congresses were associated with reductions in total outlays, although two periods were also associated with increases in nondefense outlays.
- C. The periods of undivided Congresses were associated with increases in total outlays, whereas all the periods of divided Congresses were associated with reductions in either nondefense outlays or defense outlays.
- D. All the periods of divided Congresses except one were associated with reductions in total outlays, whereas the periods of undivided Congresses were associated with increases in total outlays.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The claim is that divided Congresses are necessary but insufficient—that is, we need divide Congresses, but they are not enough—to decrease government size, as measured by total federal outlays. This choice accurately expresses the supporting data from the “change in total outlays” part of the graph. Within the data set, divided Congresses sometimes decreased total outlays, but undivided ones never did.

Choice A is incorrect. The claim is only about government size, as measured by total federal outlays—defense and nondefense outlays aren’t relevant. Choice B is incorrect. The claim is only about government size as measured by total federal outlays—nondefense outlays aren’t relevant. Choice C is incorrect. The claim is only about government size as measured by total federal outlays—specific information about defense or nondefense outlays isn’t relevant.